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W.O. Carpenter and the California Gold Rush: the making of entrepreneurial opportunities

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to trace the entrepreneurial opportunity identification process of William Oscar Carpenter (WOC), a nineteenth century farmer, who went to California in 1850 to make his fortune in gold mining and ended up starting several new business ventures. The paper seeks to recount WOC's experiences and then apply them to similar issues faced by entrepreneurs in a modern-day developing economy.

Design/methodology/approach – Using qualitative inquiry through archival research, the paper examines a compilation of WOC's letters to his future wife in New York. The letters provide a detailed account of the hardships and poor living conditions faced by gold seekers. The letters are examined and interpreted in the context of opportunity identification and the California Gold Rush, then applied to contemporary entrepreneurs.

Findings – WOC's letters elucidate the difficulties encountered making the trip from the East Coast to California, give later generations an historical viewpoint on a variety of social issues, and detail WOC's entrepreneurial activities in California. After a brief period as a successful miner, WOC's business career developed and branched out in different directions as he perceived entrepreneurial opportunities associated with the California Gold Rush. His story is an excellent example of opportunity recognition that has implications for current entrepreneurial activity.

Originality/value – WOC's awareness, anticipation, and timely action regarding business opportunity can be related, compared and contrasted with entrepreneurial activity today. The paper discusses these implications in light of opportunity recognition research and developing entrepreneurial economies.

Keywords Entrepreneurs, History, Gold, Mining, United States of America

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Entrepreneurial opportunities occur when "new goods, services, raw materials, markets and organizing methods can be introduced through the formation of new means, ends, or means-ends relationships" (Eckhardt and Shane, 2003, p. 336). An individual's ability to recognize an opportunity is regarded in recent research as a crucial first step in launching an entrepreneurial venture (Kirzner, 1985; Baron, 2006; Eckhardt and Shane, 2003; Ardichvili *et al.*, 2003). Opportunity identification is also a key element in the historical development of entrepreneurial thought (Murphy *et al.*, 2006). This paper provides students of management and entrepreneurship with an historical perspective on opportunity identification by considering the career of William Oscar (W.O.)

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Carpenter (WOC), a nineteenth century New York farmer who became a successful entrepreneur by recognizing key opportunities during the California Gold Rush.

We utilize qualitative inquiry into archival documents as both a linkage and a lens to assess the detailed letters that WOC wrote to his future wife that chronicled his entrepreneurial journey. This method is both appropriate and useful given the availability of these artifacts, which were transcribed and kept in the family for generations, and given that the general thesis and validity of the letters are corroborated by Carpenter family oral tradition to this day (Dr John Carpenter, 2007, written communication). This study is important because WOC's personal characteristics combined with his awareness, anticipation, and timely action regarding business opportunity allow us to relate, compare and contrast his experiences with entrepreneurial activity today.

Economist Schumpeter (1934) identified sources of change that can lead to opportunities:

- the creation of new products or services;
- the discovery of new geographical markets;
- the changes that emerge from creation or discovery of new raw materials;
- the opportunities created via new means of production; and
- changes generated from new ways of organizing.

WOC's story involved recognition of opportunities that resulted from a new geographic market and from discovery of new raw materials: gold in Northern California.

Stories of opportunity recognition and exploitation that involved supplying California miners and others with goods and services are not unusual, e.g. Levi Strauss (Williams, 1997), but WOC provides an example of unintended entrepreneurship involving a person who started out for California seeking gold, worked in the gold fields and then turned to business. His long entrepreneurial career was spent founding and managing several enterprises in California, Wisconsin, Michigan, Illinois and South Dakota, and he exemplifies an entrepreneur who engaged in an active search for opportunities and displayed alertness to changed conditions and to previously overlooked possibilities (Kirzner, 1985) to act upon them. WOC's story illustrates Baron's (2006, p. 107) proposition that:

> [. . .] opportunities emerge from a complex pattern of changing conditions – changes in technology, economic, political, social and demographic conditions. They come into existence at a given point in time because of a juxtaposition or confluence of conditions which did not exist previously but is now present.

A study of WOC's letters also provides the reader with background on the hardships and poor living conditions faced by gold seekers in making the trip from the East Coast to California, gives later generations an historical viewpoint on a variety of social issues such as slavery, women's rights, Chinese immigrants and the pending Civil War, and provides insights on how WOC's business career developed and branched out in several different directions.

W.O. Carpenter: the California Gold Rush experience

WOC was born on October 7, 1823 in Chateaugay, NY, in the Adirondack District of the state. WOC's ancestors in North America originated in Massachusetts before a branch of

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the family moved to Connecticut and later Vermont before moving west to New York to continue business opportunities in farming. When WOC was a young boy, his family moved farther west settling near the town of Pike in Wyoming County, NY. With only three months of formal education, WOC aspired to make a fortune in the newly discovered gold fields of California, and decided to band with like-minded young men from his hometown to embark on the treacherous journey to San Francisco via steamship in 1850. WOC's remarkable experiences are captured by letters sent to his sweetheart Lucetta Spencer, whom he later married on February 8, 1853 on a brief and rare visit back to New York. The content of these letters was later devotedly summarized by WOC's very capable second son, Dr Frederick Ives Carpenter, Sr (1861-1925) (FIC) who became a professor in the English Department at the University of Chicago. The block quotations contained in this paper are taken from this typewritten single-spaced 18-page document that has been preserved by the Carpenter (Circa 1910) family [1].

Travel hardships

WOC and his neighborhood buddies embarked on the steamship voyage from New York City on April 27, 1850. As the following narrative illustrates, there was a severe barrier to entry into the Gold Rush entrepreneurial opportunity because of travel hardships. WOC's group could only afford passage in the low-cost steerage section of the ship. Carpenter (Circa 1910) writes the following to Lucetta regarding meals on the steamship:

> The table was hung up by ropes, over one of the most dirty, worst scented portions of the ship, around which we gathered in an upright posture, with tin plates and tin cups. For bread we had sea biscuit, for potatoes the poorest I ever saw, for meat beef. Well, all put together was not so good as potatoes and salt at home. Now for serving up, of all the scenes at table that scene was king of all; for pulling, hauling, yelling, snatching, jamming, and good nature it beat all. This is only a partial description of that table, but it must suffice for that and all other meals, which were about the same, – no better I assure you. But do not tell many of this, for you may frighten them from coming.

The boat landed in Havana, Cuba for a short time before continuing west to the Isthmus of Panama. As was common for travelers at that time, the party initially headed up the Chagres River to Gorgona before traveling by land across the Isthmus of Panama. They arrived in Panama City on May 17, 1850 but could find no steamer leaving for California for a number of weeks, so they were forced to charter a boat that would sail for San Francisco. While in Panama, Carpenter (Circa 1910) unfortunately became involved in a fight with the natives that quickly got out of control, further illustrating travel hazards associated with the Gold Rush opportunity:

> June 23 1850. You should have seen the natives in the affray that occurred while I was there (at Panama) between the Yanks and them and you would have been satisfied that ere long that country must come under our sway [. . .] There were three men from the States killed and three natives before I came away [. . .] [The fight was] caused by a native stealing from some person come from the States a considerable sum of money; and said native being taken by the American and his friends, and while conducting him to some place of safety he was rescued from their hands by the natives [. . .] I was in a part of the affray, but escaped without being hurt [. . .] Had it not been for the American Consul there would have been then a battle without doubt that would have driven the natives out of house and home.

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After surviving the skirmish along with his companions, WOC recalls that there was considerable demand to sail from Panama to San Francisco, but there were few available ships. This situation prompted speculators to increase the price of tickets from the normal $150 per person to $500:

> June 26, 1850. Tickets, and those [for] steerage too, have been sold only a week before I arrived at Panama for $500 dollars, and the regular price is $150 dollars [. . .] (We) supposed we were safe in regard to fare, for they gave us a bill of fare for every day, and that was good enough, when we bought our tickets. But the reality we find to be far different (cost of passage $200 dollars). If it is possible to make them smart for the fraud, when we arrive at San Francisco, we shall institute legal proceedings against them (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

As in the Atlantic part of the voyage, Carpenter (Circa 1910) and his companions again were faced with horrific living conditions while sailing the Pacific, including a scarcity of water and near unpalatable food, despite the agreement made at the outset from Panama:

> July 5, 1850. Yesterday [we were] put on an allowance of water. Picture to yourself a large troops stove with two boilers, one for boiling tainted hams, musty pork, beef as bad as either; the other for making tea and coffee of such a character as to hold material of a heavier substance than wood. Occasionally rice boiled in salt water for dinner and supper all in one, and sometimes pudding made of flour and therein a piece of dried apple. Said pudding would answer for an anchor on account of heft. Judge also the effect of having every day going into the Captain's cabin good palatable food, which by agreement we were to have the same.

WOC, in his next letter to Lucetta, describes his fellow travelers aboard the vessel that is transporting the group from Panama to San Francisco. This description illustrates the considerable variation of persons seeking entrepreneurial success:

> July 9, 1850. Oh! This eternal pitching of the boat. There are about 250 persons on board and I am as well acquainted with them as though I had seen them on land for twenty years [. . .] Here are doctors, lawyers, mechanics, farmers, in fact men of all and every profession from the cobbler to the Texas dualist. Thus, you perceive the variety is great and characters as different as there are persons in number. Each person is different in speech, action, walk, build, dress, yet all have the same end to obtain by this voyage, their fortune (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

Launch of California mining career

After 80 days of coping with adverse living conditions as well as other risks of peril, WOC and his companions arrived in San Francisco on July 17, 1850. Although undoubtedly relieved to have escaped the confines of the ship and its relative misery, Carpenter (Circa 1910) describes to Lucetta that San Francisco at this time was dominated by saloons and gambling:

> July 18, 1850. Yesterday we arrived at this place [San Francisco]. It fully meets my expectations. It has every appearance of thrift and prosperity and all the characteristics of a new place. I went around to all or to many of the Saloons last night and at most of them there were from five to seven stands for gambling, causing us to remark that every third house almost is a gambling house. Thus, you see the cause of many not succeeding here by their losing all they earn in these Hells on Earth [. . .] I leave today for Sacramento and then for the mines.

After arriving in the Sacramento Valley, Carpenter's (Circa 1910) first impressions were not positive, which provides contextual insight into the discouragement that many like-minded Gold Rush entrepreneurs undoubtedly faced:

> September 1, 1850. At this place I found the news most discouraging, but kept up good courage and am doing well now. This place demands more courage and determined perseverance than any other, I believe, in the world. I am making this time from ten to twelve dollars per day and believe I shall do well with the blessings of Providence attending me. My place of labor at this time in on the middle fork of the American River at a bar called Oregon opposite to a bar by the name of Spanish Bar [about 60 miles from Sacramento].

Although WOC enjoyed good health, others in his company were not so fortunate, illustrating the health hazards of the entrepreneurial opportunity. Carpenter (Circa 1910) describes this factor in his September 1, 1850 letter:

> My health is first rate. All the rest of the company good, save Q. Adams. Calvin Gates is dead. He died after an illness of only five and 1/2 days. His disease was inflammation of the brain.

WOC describes the conditions in the mining fields as difficult although the potential for finding gold is great, but many prospectors are unable to cope with the harsh living. As was common among miners (Churchill, 1977), Carpenter (Circa 1910) ends the letter with advice on where to send his next mail:

> September 1, 1850 [. . .] The mines as I find them are filled to overflowing – plenty of gold, but not to be got by all the thousands come to the mines, and are not courageous enough to strike among all the difficulties that beset them on the first onset, and so go back discouraged and disheartened to their homes, if they have money enough to get them home [. . .] You may understand how it affects most men here by one fact I will give you. In the vessel we came in from Panama to San Francisco were about 250 passengers. They came into the mines, and 130 of them returned on her when she sailed back, which was in about four weeks [. . .] I expect to become almost a barbarian before I come back, for society is indeed a blank here [. . .] Direct your letters to Sacramento.

WOC moved later in the summer of 1850 to Roses' Bar on the Yuba River. He has had time at this point to fully absorb the subculture of the mining life, and finds it deplorable:

> I have nerved my heart and steeled my hand to write you from this barbarous land. I have laid down shovel and pick to take up paper, pen and ink and write you a few lines from this State where the golden placers be; and sure it is a barbarous land, for vice of every kind, dissipation, sloth and crime, men of every nation, rank and station, name, shape, color and hue abound. No place in all God's creation like this self same California. Men at home of respectable habits and standing come here and soon become reckless and dissolute from want of the success they dreamed of, expecting to make their fortune without any effort; too indolent to work or make the necessary efforts in this country that are required in any country. The consequence is vice, immorality, gambling of every kind abound. Liquors of every kind, not used as a drink but poured down these worse than brutes, making society a perfect sink of pollution. One cause of this is the want of women's restraining influence, the want of [. . .] some one at home to call the wanderer from evil influences after a day of toil or to cheer one after disappointment and misfortune (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

During this period of US history, irrigation had yet to be effectively used. Other miners, such as Buffum (1959) and Jesse Smart (Blodgett, 1999) perceived California's agricultural potential, but WOC scoffed at this idea. His next letter to Lucetta is humorous regarding his prediction of California's agricultural promise and livability. Of course, the future did prove Carpenter (Circa 1910) wrong as this portion of California (San Joaquin Valley)

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eventually became one of the finest agricultural areas of the world, and the entire state's population now exceeds 30 million:

> California will never be used to any extent for farming purposes, in spite of what Butler King says of her farming qualities in his celebrated report last winter. The country will be mining country and that will be its chief characteristic. Who ever heard of a mining country being a desirable country to live in? I never did. Neither is this. Nor will I stay after I get a decent sum of its glittering dust.

WOC later described some details of his mining exploits, as well as his success to that point and his prospects for the future. It is interesting to note that WOC was not discouraged easily, and this tenacity was a necessary personal characteristic for success in the mines. It is important to keep in mind that a good day's wages at that time was about one dollar:

> Now for a short description of my mining in this country. I began in Georgetown [. . .] We were about two weeks digging there. We moved down on to the Spanish Bar, and there dug about five weeks, or six, making about two hundred dollars for my share. Then moved on to the place I am at now, and have made in all about eleven hundred dollars. Am going to send my brother about eight or nine hundred dollars in a few days. The best day's work I have made $96, next $64, next best $50 [. . .] We thought things looked dubious in our first debut in the mines, and so they did; but kept good courage and have done well, and the prospect before us is first rate. Thus, you see the chance for me to come home in a short time comparatively speaking is good. Four others and myself have three claims that will realize us two thousand dollars a piece next summer if they turn out as well as those above them or below have done (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

Even though Carpenter (Circa 1910) is doing better than average in the mines, his living conditions are quite rudimentary:

> The house we live in is made of cloth about twelve feet in diameter and round. Over this we have another cloth drawn within about four inches of it, and these two together keep us dry and warm with a fireplace.

With the summer gone, WOC pursued "dry diggings" for the winter quarter. WOC's attitude seems to dip, probably due to loneliness, depression and exhaustion. He continually states that there is no hope for agriculture in California, which seems to be one of his favorite harping points, along with the general barrenness of the landscape. Apparently, WOC wrote about fifteen letters to Lucetta until he finally received one from her (around September or October 1850). WOC's son FIC, who typed his letters, noted that Carpenter (Circa 1910) was apparently especially homesick when he wrote Lucetta the following letter dated November 26, 1850, which also puts his mining success into perspective:

> I would not live in California if they would give me all her bleak and desolate hills and barren plains, no, no, never [. . .] Do not think because I have stated how well I throve in the few last days I was digging that I would advise any person to come here. No, right to the contrary, for where there is one who has done well there are twenty that have not, this year.

In his letter to Lucetta dated December 22, 1850, WOC discusses some of the major political issues raging during these times before assuring his future bride that he will not ask her to make the arduous trip to California. He alludes to the recently passed Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 and the negative reaction to it in the northern states. Part of the

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Compromise of 1850, the Act provided broad federal powers to issue arrest warrants, form posses, and determine the status of alleged fugitive slaves while also denying legal rights to accused runaways (Kotlowski, 2003). The Act also offered financial incentives to federal commissioners to return slaves to their masters (Kotlowski, 2003). Carpenter (Circa 1910) also mentions the movement championing equal rights for women:

> The progressive spirit is still alive in the minds of mankind and gaining ground. This is clear to us who hope and believe in this spirit. I see it too in the indignant spirit manifested by the North in regard to the late law passed by Congress for the recovery of fugitive slaves. It is also seen in the women's rights convention held at Worcester, Mass [. . .] A better day is dawning and downtrodden woman will have her just rights. Let us be of the few to help the cause along, yet with discretion [. . .] Fear not, I shall not ask you to come to this land to live. Yet I may ask you to go to the western states [e.g., states now considered part of the Midwest, where they later lived] though I cannot tell. But we will arrange this matter when I get home.

Carpenter's (Circa 1910) December 22, 1850 letter to Lucetta Spencer also discusses what life is like apart from his work as a miner:

> Now for a description of the manners, fashions, mode of living, etc. Of the people here [. . .] Our dwelling – tents or log huts covered with canvas. Eating utensils – knife and fork, tin plates. Food – flour, Indian meal. Chief articles cooked according to the taste and ability of the cook. I have so far learned the art of cooking as to make good bread, Indian cakes, short cakes, etc. Fashion for dress – ragged pants, shirts, and coats, or large patches on them [. . .] Hair long, beard two years growth or more. Know nobody, nor nobody knows you. Great country this!

Having survived the boredom of winter, WOC writes Lucetta on March 26, 1851 of his current situation and plans for the future. It is in this letter that Carpenter (Circa 1910) describes his first attempts to diversify his interests with the help of leverage from his uncle:

> I am still at Roses Bar and shall be all summer. Have made the past winter $750 dollars, which I have paid out for claims and a part of a store and a farm, and have borrowed some few hundred dollars of an Uncle I have here to make out the balance I had to pay. I think the prospects are good for the coming summer. Have made since I have been in California seventeen hundred or eighteen hundred dollars clear from expenses, and shall stay until fall and perhaps until next spring, for if possible I must have a decent sum to bring home. So take it patiently until I come.

Pursuing new venture opportunities: first-year anniversary

About this time, WOC's entrepreneurial character begins to show. Unlike the more famous Levi Strauss, who migrated to California expressly to sell dry goods to miners at the urging of his sister and brother-in-law who were already doing so (Williams, 1997), WOC began as a miner. Although he enjoyed great success in the mines, he recognized better opportunities in business supporting the efforts of other miners. WOC's April 27, 1851 letter home marks the one-year anniversary of his departure for California. He describes a newly found professional credential that marks further his business diversification efforts – selling mules to other miners:

> I have got an M.D. attached to my name, but it stands for quite a different thing in California than it does at home. I have turned *Mule Driver* and am in the city (Sacramento) every week buying goods to take into the mines (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

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Other miners made similar attempts to move into trade, with varying degrees of success. Buffum (1959) tells of one man who bought a mule and sold trinkets and luxury items to the miners, only to mismanage his money and start over again. Marryat (1952) tells of another who went to great expense to sell whiskey from a cart at the mines, only to have several competitors with lower prices the next day. Numerous miners would identify the same shortage, leading to great fluctuations in supplies: one year all whiskey, no coal. Next year all coal, but no whiskey. The keys to success were to anticipate needs before others and to avoid losing the rewards through excessive drinking or gambling. WOC had the former anticipatory skills while not suffering from the vices of the latter. His letters illustrate his personal drive, ambition, and self-discipline, which continue to be characteristics common among successful entrepreneurs. It is likely that his clean lifestyle was due in part to personal religious beliefs, since his obituary in 1905 made it very clear that he was a devoted Christian Scientist. Discussions with the Carpenter family indicate that WOC's personality could be described as a "velvet brick"; he had a kind exterior but was extremely tough, persistent and resilient, and he always was aware of possible business diversification opportunities[2].

Continued success and change in attitude: late 1851

WOC's mood and attitude seem to change during the latter part of 1851. It is hard to tell why, other than the fact that his financial situation continues to improve. In his letter to Lucetta dated November 15, 1851, WOC recounts his financial exploits as well as naming his business partners. Carpenter (Circa 1910) closes his letter by cautioning Lucetta to use his full middle name because of confusion caused by another person in Sacramento with a similar name:

> I am in trade here and doing well. Have made (since I sent home some $800 dollars to Brother Augustus) in the neighborhood of four thousand dollars [. . .] I have had two partners, one a man by the name of Clark, and Wells of our place [Pike, NY]. Mr Clark has done the selling and I the buying. Having claims to tend to we had Wells for a third partner, whom we have bought out, and before this gets to you he will be in Pike. I can tell you our amount of business by saying that I have paid out for the last three months from eight to fifteen hundred dollars every week for goods in gold dust [. . .] Do not fail to put on the outside of every letter my middle name in full, as there is a person by the name of W.O. Carpenter in this city besides myself (signed).

In the following letter dated December 21, 1851, WOC provides continued evidence that his spirits are high and that his initial negative impression of the Sacramento Valley is changing dramatically. In fact, WOC starts to view California positively as compared with his former home in Pike, NY. In addition to the impact of continued success, it is also distinctly possible that WOC wishes to point out the positives in California as part of an overall scheme to convince Lucetta Spencer to eventually join him there. Carpenter (Circa 1910) also mentions his recent diversification into the foundry business:

> It seems to me now, from being accustomed to this beautiful clime and genial skies, as though it were impossible to feel in that cold bleak country as we do in this sunny clime. Oh! it is a beautiful climate to live in; scenery which none can surpass [. . .]
>
> If you were only here I could live contented for three or four years at least; but it is a poor society to bring a woman to as yet, although the prospect is that next year will bring an influx

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> of ladies into this country that will change society in a great measure [. . .] I am in business in Sacramento and shall be for the next year. I am in the foundry business and hope to do well.

WOC is not only lonely but also thinks often of how he can structure the logistics to marry his sweetheart Lucetta. The main barrier is the considerable difficulty and risk for either of them to travel. WOC's second son FIC, who transcribed WOC's letters to Lucetta, describes how WOC explained to Lucetta that it was not yet advisable for him to come home to Pike. It was difficult to find a business partner he could trust to carry on the business and he would lose the opportunity to make $6 to $8 a day. Sacramento was a bustling business center by 1851, where "an immense quantity of sign-boards stare at you in every direction; [to] induce a man to purchase . . . any article for which he has no want" (Marryat, 1952, p. 203), Thus, WOC was rightly concerned about abandoning business at that time.

WOC also discusses the possibility of Lucetta coming out to California in the company of a lady and her father as well as his brother Augustus so WOC and Lucetta could marry. In a postscript dated December 22, 1851, it is clear WOC is going to marry his sweetheart in the near future, one way or another. In closing, he states his financial success before an attempt to get into Lucetta's world by making conversation about a cause that is dear to her, women's rights:

> If you should come to me we can be married immediately on your arrival [. . .] (Then) I should not be obliged to keep Bachelors Hall as I do now. Answer me as your own good sense and feeling dictate and I shall be content, for if it is necessary I shall sell out to come next fall at any cost, if you do not come to me. You cannot conceive how lonely it is to a person like me here, for I do not nor cannot enjoy what many do here; dissipation, vice, or theater-going every night do not suit me [. . .] As near as I can tell have made in the last year from four thousand five hundred to five thousand dollars, and expect to double it in another year [. . .] How fares woman's rights? Do they improve in quantity? (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

Mining support business expansion: early 1852

WOC's son, FIC, interjects the following information that gives clues to WOC's business diversification efforts in addition to the foundry business mentioned above. During the early months of 1852 WOC abandoned mining and chose to instead focus exclusively on mining support business ventures. It is clear that there were significant risks with Carpenter's (Circa 1910) business activities, as evidenced by FIC's narrative regarding bandits:

> In the interim between the letters [circa 1852] he [WOC] had abandoned mining and opened up a store. He occasionally, however, bought and sold mining claims. At regular intervals he drove to Sacramento for supplies and to carry out gold dust. The bandits who infested the roads did not molest him, for he had become a dead shot with the revolver (the "drop shot") and always went armed.

FIC's narrative also highlights that a letter from Lucetta mentions a rumor WOC had been shot by Indians. WOC denies it in a January 1852 letter to Lucetta but states that "I have not been unarmed since I have been on the road this last summer" (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

Carpenter's (Circa 1910) letter to Lucetta dated February 11, 1852 describes the social climate of the region which provides additional environmental context, and closes with his hope that his brother Augustus will soon join him in Sacramento:

> Our quiet city of Sacramento has been excited for the last two months to a considerable extent. The first event was a mother shooting a man for seducing her daughter, for which she was not blamed at all. My echo was, served him right [. . .] Another case of shooting this morning occurred. A man found his honor betrayed by his wife, and he shot the man who was the cause of it. I say, served him right [. . .] A few lessons of this kind will be salutary, however much we deplore them [. . .] I am intending to write to brother Augustus and have him come to this fair clime of ours, and then shall be home next fall at any cost. Families are coming here in scores on every steamer. God bless them all! What a wide field for enterprise is opening on every side of this country.

Whereas San Francisco was famous for its frequent fires, Sacramento was regularly flooded by streams and rivers (Blodgett, 1999). WOC's letter to Lucetta dated March 22, 1852 mentions that Sacramento was recently flooded, and that he lost about $300 in damages due to the flood. The following excerpts describe the humorous side of the minor tragedy:

> All seems to feel well and enjoy the chance to ride in boats through the streets, on rafts, in boxes, on planks and every way that ingenuity could devise; and if perchance some unlucky hombre or person should fall into the water there were scores to laugh at him, standing on the sidewalks; for the water was only about two or three feet deep in the deepest places; one foot was about the average where boats could run (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

Like other men who had gone to California to seek their fortunes, WOC was torn between the money he was making in business and his desire for beginning a family life befitting a man of his upbringing. In using WOC as a case study of family and gender relationships during the Gold Rush, Eifler (2002, p. 235) suggests that WOC's notion of success would have demanded he marry:

> Torn at last between his gold rush successes and his family, Carpenter for years tried to manage both [. . .] Such were the ambitions of California's gold rush dreamers. Most hoped to have wealth and family status.

WOC outlines his plans to come back to Pike to marry Lucetta in his letter to her dated April 16, 1852. It appears that the plan is to entrust his business affairs to his brother Augustus after acclimating him to the many dealings and then proceed east. Here, Carpenter (Circa 1910) also mentions his trading post, the latest twist in his many diversification efforts:

> As soon as Augustus arrives here I shall go into the mines to my trading post, and be on the road all summer, and let him stay here, for he will not be acquainted with the mines and cannot do as well as I can; and I shall come home in the fall and then should want him here. Thus, you see it is necessary for me to do so, although it be the hardest work by a great deal for me.

Second year anniversary: loneliness and observable Chinese discrimination

The following excerpt is from WOC's letter to Lucetta dated April 18, 1852, where Carpenter (Circa 1910) again describes his intense loneliness as he approaches the two-year anniversary of his departure from Pike:

> It is eve now. Will you join me in a walk and trust to my guidance to conduct you along the banks of the Sacramento, and view the beauties of an April eve? Methinks I hear Yes, come out in joyous tones. But that cannot be, and so must be content to write you [. . .] Aye, feasts of

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> reason, flow of soul. And kindred spirits to enjoy it with, which we have not here. Woman with her sunny smiles, cheering tones, and helping hands, is wanting [. . .] If my memory serves it is just two years from this date since I left you in Wyoming (County).

In an additional entry dated April 25, Carpenter (Circa 1910) mentions the shocking immorality of certain ladies who have arrived in that region:

> I have been looking around me and noticing men and women; and women in particular so far exceed in vice and immorality every standard that I formed for her prior to my leaving home that it astonishes me.

By the end of 1852, there were about 25,000 Chinese nationals in California, and as their numbers increased, so too did violence and hostility against them. They often responded by choosing picked-over gold deposits already abandoned by white miners or by starting laundries or restaurants that required low-capital investment and allowed them to avoid competing with whites for jobs (Oakland Museum of California, 1998). The Chinese were also forced to pay a tax to the local Chinese leaders, analogous to indentured servitude. Miner and writer Marryat (1952, p. 300) noted that the Chinese miners were "poor fisherman, whose profits serve to enrich a clique . . . the principle is . . . antagonistic to the principles which have made [California] a free state as regards black slavery." WOC seemed to have an especial admiration for the Chinese laborers. In a May 7, 1852 letter to Lucetta, he notes that the Chinese faced intense discrimination:

> Another sight met my eye, which extended as far as I could see, was the road lined with Chinese with their cues hanging down their backs as long or longer than any woman's hair at home and their style of dress so antique that I could not refrain from smiling [. . .] the vast numbers that are coming, who without doubt will be driven out of the mines by the miners (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

FIC interjects here an anecdote that occurred many years later when he traveled with his father Carpenter (Circa 1910). back to this part of California in 1892:

> Driving into Roses Bar, now Smartsville, we met a picturesque party of Chinamen, marching to some feast and carrying on their shoulders in a large wooden litter a pig roasted whole. WOC thought well of the Chinese, and related an incident in the old days when he and other miners stood by to see fair play when a couple of Chinamen attacked and drove out an Irishman who had jumped their claim.

Brother Augustus arrives, WOC leaves to marry: 1852

On May 13, 1852, brother Augustus finally arrived in San Francisco in good health except for a bad cold. WOC's letter to Lucetta dated May 15, 1852 mentions how much he enjoyed visiting with Augustus and how much he appreciated the gifts she sent with him. In his letter dated May 25, 1852, Carpenter (Circa 1910) again outlines his dilemma while also mentioning that Lucetta is employed as a schoolteacher in Pike:

> Who would have a girl at home and not have a chance to see her in three years? Who would (do) a penny business at home when they can do a dollar business here? Who would live in a frozen clime when they can live in a temperate zone? [. . .] Here's a long life to you and may you teach school until you are satisfied!

Carpenter's (Circa 1910) letter dated June 29, 1852 mentions that he is no longer a mule driver while describing his current business activities:

> This summer I am driving team as last summer, save I do not drive mules this summer but horses. So you see I have lost my title of M.D. [. . .] I have let A (his brother Augustus) stay in Sac City and tend to business, while I am taking hard knocks. But I deemed it best. He has had the fever and ague and very weak; but is getting better.

Carpenter (Circa 1910) letter to Lucetta on July 13, 1852 from Sacramento highlights his successful financial situation to date:

> You would be well pleased to know something of my business. Well, I have some six thousand dollars in foundry property, in connection with my partner in the mines; and some five or six river-shores that are worth as many thousand dollars; and our goods in our store. So that if I have any decent fortune this summer in our business I shall be worth from eight to twelve thousand dollars this fall; but cannot tell in this uncertain country. But am expecting to come home this coming December with about five thousand dollars and leave about the same amount in good property here [. . .] My health is good, but not as well as I was when mining. My love to all; and to little sister say I am her brother William the same as ever.

In his August 11, 1852 letter, WOC is obviously anxious to return to Pike to marry his sweetheart. He also mentions that a friend back home with the first initial "T" apparently came to California but did not last long, which again highlights the difficulty of the California experience. By now, California emigration is also across the plains rather than exclusively by steamer:

> Time flies quickly by and lessens the days to be spent in California before I see my friends at home [. . .] Business is now first rate in the mines with me and expect it will continue so until December, and then, Ho! for my girl at home [. . .] I did not see *T*_____ while here. Think he took the wisest course in going home; but would have been wiser in staying at home in the first place. But if it had been me, would not have left until I had made a thorough trial. But he is not the kind for California [. . .] The emigration is coming in from across the plains fast, and plenty of women coming. California is bound to be a great place (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

FIC interjects here that WOC returned at last to Pike in late 1852. WOC spent the winter there and was married to Lucetta Spencer on February 8, 1853. He then started back without her for California in the spring of 1853, again by steamship (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

Travel back to California: 1853

The next letter of which we have record is dated May 25, 1853. In this very long letter that WOC wrote while on the steamship en route to San Francisco for the second time, he describes the rigors of his travel, especially the overland route over the Isthmus of Panama accompanied by his brother Lucius, who apparently is not as keen a businessman as WOC. Carpenter (Circa 1910) also mentions the significant business losses he has suffered while absent from California, which decimated his seed capital needed to restart his many business ventures there:

> Still on the briney deep. Started from Panama one week ago this evening, and have been sick all the time until today. Thus, you see I have my time of seasickness, but think if I had not been on the Isthmus so long should not have been seasick at all on this side.
>
> By all I can find out the rainy season has hung on to California this spring remarkably, so that I have no hopes of my business being anything but destroyed in Sac City, thus giving me not more that two or three thousand dollars to begin with. I must be careful, and my wife also [. . .]

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> If you should ever come to California be sure and procure upper Saloon State-room. In the purchase of a ticket Lucius did not tend to it right, and if he had not been in such a hurry he might have got tickets for $200, instead of $250 [. . .]
>
> [. . .] (I will) send for you or come to you as soon as possible, although it does not seem to me now that I shall send for you, for it would be a hard journey for you, very hard. Yet there are women not half as capable as you are that have come alone.
>
> [. . .] I have given you most of the particulars about crossing the Isthmus [. . .] Some ladies came across the same day I did (the distance 26 miles) and when they got off their horses they could not stand; some of them fainted; while others plied the whip to their mules and went through the streets of Panama as fast as they could make their mules go [. . .] It would not be a bad plan for you to ride some before you start, and arrange your dress before you start [. . .]
>
> I started from Gorgona the morning of the 13th of May at six o'c. A.M. afoot with a companion. Left Lucius [and] my chum's companion to overtake us with the mules and then change with them and let them walk. We pressed on through the mud until I walked 22 miles before L. overtook (us), leaving only four miles for me to ride. I felt just as able to walk the four miles as I did when I started in the morning [. . .] Up hill, down valley, through narrow causeway I came; covered with mud from head to foot I arrived in Pan(ama).

Further business in California, financial crisis in New York and predictions: 1854-1855

At this juncture, there is a year-long gap in the preserved letters. The next recorded letter is from WOC to Lucetta in Pike, NY dated May 28, 1854 sent from Roses Bar. In this letter, WOC tries again to lay the groundwork to bring his new wife to California, noting that conditions have gotten much better and the associated dangers are dwindling. It appears that WOC had made numerous promises, both to his new wife as well as to her parents. Carpenter (Circa 1910) also refers to "the little one" who is the newlywed couple's newborn son (Warren Spencer Carpenter, b. December 15, 1853):

> [. . .] I am going to decide whether it will be best for you to come to me next fall or not (although I think it will be best), and stay here about two years [. . .] I cannot be satisfied unless we are together next winter; and this is and was my promise to you and to your parents, that you shall be at home in three years if you come to me [. . .]
>
> Business here has better prospects for three years to come than it did the last year, for the development of these old hills shows that they are full of gold; and I am acquainted here and deem it the place for me to stay until I am able to stay where I please [. . .] Now, the danger of health to you and the little one by fall will be nothing.

WOC's next letter to his wife is written from Sacramento City, dated June 24, 1854. This letter updates Carpenter's (Circa 1910) business activities:

> I still am driving team, buying goods to take to the mines [. . .] A cool summer so far and all well. Vegetation has put on its sere and yellow look of summer, and all partakes of its golden hue.

Apparently, Lucetta made the decision to not risk the dangers and difficulties of traveling with her baby boy to join WOC in California. Carpenter (Circa 1910) writes on August 22, 1854, concurring with his wife's decision: "Now about your future coming, do not do so unless I send for you, for if possible I will leave California for good in the course of six months".

WOC's next letter (dated February 3, 1855 from Roses Bar) again attempts to justify his continued business activities in California, despite the fact that he undoubtedly misses his wife and baby and may be under pressure to return home. The letter makes

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clear that WOC wishes to financially situate his family so he and Lucetta can raise their children and provide them a good education. His reluctance to leave a successful business to return to New York was undoubtedly influenced by recent economic history.

A banking panic that began in New York in 1837, when WOC was 14, and spread through the rest of the country led to "exceedingly disturbed economic conditions and a long contraction to 1843," (Friedman, 1960, p. 10) when WOC was 20. According to Friedman (1960), this was the only US economic depression comparable in both scope and severity to the Great Depression of the 1930s. Furthermore, the banking system in New York, in particular, remained unstable. The "Safety Fund" banks, established in part in response to the banking crisis, were intended to ensure (and insure) the survival of struggling banks in New York but were showing signs of failure. About 11 safety fund banks in western New York (WOC's home) failed in the early 1840s, and by 1850, more than $2.7 million had been paid out of the fund for creditors of western New York banks (Reform Club, 1895, p. 294):

> [. . .] If we cannot by reason of circumstances elevate ourselves as we would wish, it will be our high and holy vocation if possible to so shape circumstances that we can bring up our children with all the advantages of an education rightly directed [. . .] Do not blame me for thinking it best for you to come here, for consider how hard it is to start in business at home; prostrated as it is with you, can you wonder I deem it best to stay where a man can know how much he makes and get his pay in gold that does not fail as banks do with you (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

The last letter we have was sent by WOC (from Roses Bar) to Lucetta dated February 25, 1855. WOC remarks that the railroad being built will eventually reach the Pacific. WOC also predicts that rumors of pending war in the east (Civil War) will amount to nothing. Although WOC was a brilliant entrepreneur, he was incorrect about predictions regarding future agriculture in California as well as the severity of the Civil War. However, he correctly predicted the impact of the railroads and the success of California as a state in general (if not agriculturally). Finally, WOC again refers to financial distress in his homeland of New York, and offers to help his father-in-law through the apparent economic crisis. His advice seems to be shrewd and conservative, and his suggestion that his father-in-law "look sharp at things" may imply that he should watch carefully for good investment bargains, which WOC seems to have mastered himself. The letter also indicates that he sends money home to his own family on a monthly basis for their support:

> [. . .] We may well look at one of the greatest enterprises of the day with marked interest, the Pacific Rail Road, for it is one of vast magnitude to all the earth, and to America's sons in particular, and perchance to you and me [. . .] for it may be our wish to travel over it in the course of time, yet not very probable. I more particularly look at it with great interest, for have I not seen California in its infant days, and now fast verging into strong and vigorous manhood? What she will be with this road (railroad) is not distinctly seen, but that it must be of great utility to her is plain. That I should think of this state as much or more than of any other is a natural result of being with her in her infant days and having seen her progress to its present state.
>
> [. . .] Appearances indicate that the eastern war will amount to nothing, or nearly so. Money matters with you are truly awful, and the whole country will feel its effects with you shortly [. . .] It is not the right time to invest for a year or two at home; for I should prefer to do so

> about the time things began to recover their tone. Then is the time to be successful [...] Perchance your father could use some (money) to good advantage, as I suppose he invested his money in the Peck farm and perchance could use some more [...] If he needed some to use I could send you more than I do, that is, monthly. Tell him for me to look sharp at things as they are now (Carpenter, Circa 1910).

WOC postscript: 1855-1905

FIC notes that there are no further family records of these years. He also mentions that WOC made another visit back to Pike, probably in late 1855. Apparently, he traveled home with brother Augustus, leaving brother Lucius in charge of the business interests in California. In 1856, WOC returned to California by heading west over the plains this time, taking with him a drove of horses that he later sold to the gold miner market at a great profit. The party that assisted him in crossing the plains with the horses was small, but many other emigrants attached themselves to Carpenter's (Circa 1910) group "for greater safety and protection against Indian raids". FIC reports that WOC's group was never actually attacked by Indians, "although frequently bands of Indians hovered on their flanks."

In 1856, WOC left California for good and moved his family to Monroe, Wisconsin. In 1862, he and his family, accompanied by his brothers, moved to Chicago. WOC was one of a group of investors that founded the First National Bank of Chicago. He also had many other diversified business investments that are highlighted in his obituary, including owning a lumber business, buying and selling livestock, founding the Kirby Carpenter Company in Menominee, Michigan, as well as the Carpenter Cook Company. WOC also became President of the Menominee River Sugar Company and of Lumberman's National Bank. Finally, he took great pride in the success of his large ranch in South Dakota. WOC died in Menominee on October 10, 1905 at the age of 82, leaving a fortune to his two sons and adopted daughter. He was buried in Chicago, Illinois.

Implications

WOC's entrepreneurial attributes and personal characteristics served him well during the California Gold Rush, and their usefulness in this historical context may provide both a linkage and learning template to guide contemporary entrepreneurs to similar success, even in differing business venues and cultures. For example, in the following discussion we trace some of the key entrepreneurial attributes and personal characteristics WOC displayed (in italics) and compare and contrast them to the Chinese entrepreneurial context relevant to the twenty-first century.

Recognize an opportunity

WOC recognized a significant yet inconvenient opportunity in the California Gold Rush that was only attainable after months of travel. Similarly, there is currently substantial demand in China for goods and services due to its substantial population, its metamorphosis in culture, and the acceleration of its developing economy that has occurred in the past two decades after the cultural revolution. Although entrepreneurial activity is still rare and inconvenient in China for numerous cultural and political reasons mentioned next, there is a window of opportunity for technological advances, because the Chinese government wishes for China to become a leader in this area (Liao and Sohmen, 2001).

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Willingness to take risks

WOC took significant personal health, safety, family, and financial risks during his entrepreneurial journey, and entrepreneurship in general always involves risk. This is especially true in the Chinese experience because of seemingly insurmountable barriers to entrepreneurial activity such as:

- political and legal uncertainty;
- limited access to resources, including capital and skilled labor; and
- the stigma and low-social status attributed to doing private business in China (Liao and Sohmen, 2001).

Alertness to changing conditions

WOC was remarkably able to visualize opportunities and exploit them with very little time delay. Similarly, the astute Asian businessperson must recognize that the cultural climate in China has changed enough presently to make large-scale entrepreneurial activity possible. Under Mao Zedong's cultural revolution one often was subjected to humiliation and persecution if one was even suspected of being capitalist, but this hostility is now the exception rather than the norm. WOC's flexibility allowed him to change and modify his entrepreneurial dream as well (gold miner, to mule driver, to store and foundry owner) as environmental conditions changed and new opportunities surfaced. Similarly, a Chinese entrepreneur must be willing to quickly modify plans and strategy when new opportunities arise, such as when China recently relaxed laws and granted tax breaks and monetary grants for technology development (Liao and Sohmen, 2001).

Ability to endure hardships

WOC's letters enumerate substantial physical, emotional and financial hardships during his years in California. Similar hardships await Chinese entrepreneurs. For example, the stigma of capitalist activity still exists today in Chinese culture, although it is much more likely to be tolerated. Therefore, this barrier adds to the typical entrepreneurial difficulties such as long work hours and difficulty raising capital in a Confucian society that does not trust outsiders. In China, quitting one's job is especially problematic since one often loses not only stable income and fringe benefits, but also housing assistance (Liao and Sohmen, 2001).

Willingness to separate from family

Like WOC, who had to endure many lonesome years of solitude to exploit his many business ventures, it is common in the Chinese experience for spouses to endure separation in order to pursue business or educational opportunities.

Perseverance, tenacity and ambition

These attributes of personal discipline drove WOC to overcome financial setbacks and risk of bodily injury. A Chinese entrepreneur wishing to exploit technological opportunities must possess these attributes to overcome seemingly insurmountable social, political, cultural, and financial odds, which WOC was able to do during his remarkable career.

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Conclusion

WOC's letters provide the modern reader with an extensive view of the economic and social conditions of his time, as we explored and detailed using qualitative inquiry and interpretation of available documents, which have been described as the bread and butter of the historical method in management history (Lamond, 2006). The letters also indicate Carpenter's successful transition from gold miner to entrepreneur in early California.

From mule driver to store owner to foundry operator, WOC's work as an entrepreneur during the California Gold Rush documents an ability to take advantage of a variety of market opportunities and provides insight into the progression of opportunity recognition – "the cognitive process (or processes) through which individuals conclude that they have identified an opportunity" (Baron, 2006, p. 107). The importance of WOC's knack in seizing opportunities, once recognized, differentiates him from others in the gold fields. Other miners saw entrepreneurial opportunities but did not feel drawn to respond. For example, Buffum, a former soldier who kept a journal while spending six months in the mines, often mentioned business opportunities he perceived, including salmon fisheries, industrial mining, agriculture, luxury items and trinkets, and lumber (Buffum, 1959). These opportunities went largely unrealized.

WOC's letters provide insights and evidence supporting Baron's (2006, p. 108) proposition that opportunity recognition depends in part on frameworks developed by individuals through previous life experiences. Such frameworks help organize information, and serve as "templates" enabling entrepreneurs to connect the dots among seemingly unrelated changes or events, leading to new business opportunities. In light of WOC's capability to recognize such patterns, his eventual migration to the Midwest makes sense, given the poor economic outlook in New York and his family's desire that he leave California. The Great Lakes region "carried the commerce for a booming regional economy that involved at least seven states. The Great Lakes, in short, were the heart of a powerful, dynamic, far-reaching regional economy" (Egnal, 2001, p. 46). Although a part of the region, New York's instability worried WOC and pointed him from California to new venture opportunities in Michigan, Illinois and elsewhere.

Although this study, which used qualitative inquiry to trace WOC's entrepreneurial journey, contributes to the management history literature, some limitations must be noted. Although our research design is powerful, it contains weaknesses common to use and interpretation of documents. For example, it does not provide a counter thesis to the letter artifact information and interpretation of events as witnessed by WOC, and it does not control for our interpretive bias regarding the letters, as well as the possibility that not all letter artifacts were available to us. Future research might include an examination of WOC's later business ventures in the Midwest to cement his reputation as an early serial entrepreneur. Such inquiry may provide contemporary entrepreneurs a roadmap on how to both diversify and transition among business ventures.

Notes

1. The paper contains both transcribed letters from WOC and commentary by his son, FIC used in connecting the letters. Quoted material from either writer comes from the same reference, Carpenter (Circa 1910). Parentheses in the block quotes are in the original paper, whereas brackets have been added by the current authors. The authors wish to emphasize that WOC's letters were carefully transferred from original letter to typewritten form by FIC,

who was one of the first persons to earn a PhD in English at the University of Chicago. Therefore, the authors assert that the typewritten 18-page document is an accurate representation of the original letters. The authors obtained this 18-page document directly from the Carpenter family, although the same document is also publicly available. For example, Eifler (2002) mentions that he had access to the WOC document at a library in Southern California.

2. The Carpenter oral traditions about WOC were somewhat fractured because of the length of time between generations. For example, FIC was born in 1861 when WOC was already 38. FIC's (Sr) son, FIC Jr, was not born until 1903, which is but two years before his grandfather WOC died in 1905. FIC Sr died in 1925 when FIC Jr was only 22, and was not yet married. Furthermore, FIC Jr followed in his father FIC's footsteps by also earning a PhD in English from the University of Chicago, so neither FIC nor FIC Jr had a primary focus on WOC's business interests and entrepreneurial exploits.

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